

D389

Learning Strategies in Higher Education

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A working parent who studies at the kitchen table has six hours to prepare for an exam next week. Her roommate from college always studied with music on. Which plan will most likely give her the best long-term recall?

- A. Any schedule, as long as music is playing.
- B. Six one-hour sessions spread over six days.
- C. One six-hour session the night before the exam.
- D. Three hours on the first day and none after.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Two students each study 4 hours total. Student A studies 4 hours in one night; Student B studies 1 hour on each of 4 days. Which statement is correct?

- A. Student A will remember more, because focus builds over one long session.
- B. Both will remember the same, because total time is equal.
- C. Student B will likely remember more a month later.
- D. Neither will remember anything without eight hours.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A student who commutes by train has two chapters to learn. She has already highlighted them in yellow and green. Which next step will most improve her exam performance?

- A. Close the book and quiz herself with practice questions and flashcards.
- B. Reread both chapters three more times.
- C. Add a third highlighter color.
- D. Copy the chapters word for word.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After rereading her notes, a student feels sure she knows the material but scores poorly on a practice quiz. What best explains this?

- A.** She should have highlighted her notes.
- B.** Practice quizzes never reflect real exams.
- C.** She needed to reread even more times.
- D.** Rereading created a feeling of familiarity without practicing recall.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A new student who just bought a planner with a floral cover writes goals for her first term. Which goal is written in SMART form?

- A.** Finish the whole degree in one month.
- B.** Do better in school.
- C.** Use the new planner every day.
- D.** Complete two courses by March 31 by studying 10 hours each week.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A student who works part-time at a pet store has these tasks: a paper due tomorrow, reviewing notes for an exam in three weeks, answering a group chat about weekend plans, and scrolling social media. Her manager just texted about next month's schedule. Which task should she do first?

- A.** Review for the exam in three weeks.
- B.** Finish the paper due tomorrow.
- C.** Answer the manager about next month.
- D.** Reply to the group chat.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In the Eisenhower matrix, what should be done with a task that is important but not urgent, like building a weekly study plan?

- A.** Delegate it to someone else.
- B.** Do it immediately before anything else.
- C.** Schedule a specific time to do it.
- D.** Drop it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A student searching the library database for sources on sleep and memory gets 48,000 results. She is using the library’s mobile app on her tablet. How should she change her search to narrow the results?

- A.** Remove the word memory.
- B.** Combine terms with AND, such as sleep AND memory AND college students.
- C.** Switch to a laptop to get fewer results.
- D.** Use OR between terms.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student’s search for “teen” AND “anxiety” returns only 6 results. Which change will broaden it the most while staying on topic?

- A.** anxiety AND adolescent NOT teen
- B.** teen AND anxiety AND college
- C.** teen NOT anxiety
- D.** (teen OR adolescent) AND (anxiety OR worry)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A student writing about the effects of screen time on sleep finds four sources. One appears on a website with a sleek modern design. Which source is most credible for an academic paper?

- A.** A 2022 peer-reviewed study in a sleep research journal.
- B.** The website with the sleek design and no listed author.
- C.** A product page from a company that sells blue-light glasses.
- D.** A 2005 magazine article.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A student reads an article and writes the author’s main argument in her own words. She finished the paragraph at 2 a.m. and saved it to the cloud. What must she do?

- A.** Put the whole paragraph in quotation marks.
- B.** Cite only if it is used in the conclusion.
- C.** Add an in-text citation for the article.
- D.** Nothing, since the words are her own.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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12.

On a timed multiple-choice exam taken at a testing center with bright lights, a student reads a question and sees one option says the policy “always” applies. She has 40 minutes left. What is the best strategy?

- A.** Read the full stem, predict the answer, and eliminate options with absolute words unless clearly supported.
- B.** Ask for dimmer lights before answering.
- C.** Pick the first option that looks familiar.
- D.** Choose the option with always, since it sounds confident.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A working parent ~~who studies at the kitchen table~~ has six hours to prepare for an exam next week. ~~Her roommate from college always studied with music on.~~ Which plan will most likely give her the best long-term recall?

Target word: best schedule **Decides:** Same total time, spaced out.

A	Camouflage	Background music does not decide the spacing effect.
B	Correct	Spacing improves retention.
C	Inverted operation	Cramming is the opposite of spacing.
D	Dropped element	Drops half the time and the spacing.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

Two students each study 4 hours total. Student A studies 4 hours in one night; Student B studies 1 hour on each of 4 days. Which statement is correct?

Target word: compare equal totals **Decides:** Spacing, not total time.

A	Inverted operation	Massed study fades faster.
B	Dropped element	Ignores the spacing effect.
C	Correct	Spaced sessions improve long-term memory.
D	Absolute language	No such rule exists.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A student ~~who commutes by train~~ has two chapters to learn. She has already highlighted them ~~in yellow and green~~. Which next step will most improve her exam performance?

Target word: best learning activity **Decides:** Active recall beats rereading.

A	Correct	Retrieval practice strengthens memory.
B	Adjacent category	Rereading builds familiarity but little recall.
C	Camouflage	More highlighting is still passive.
D	Confusion set	Copying is passive and time-consuming.

4. Answer D Concept 2 • transfer

After rereading her notes, a student feels sure she knows the material but scores poorly on a practice quiz. What best explains this?

Target word: reverse: why rereading misleads **Decides:** Familiarity is not recall.

A	Adjacent category	Highlighting is also passive.
B	Absolute language	Practice tests are useful predictors.
C	Inverted operation	More passive review repeats the problem.
D	Correct	Recognition is easier than retrieval.

5. Answer D Concept 3

A new student who just bought a planner ~~with a floral cover~~ writes goals for her first term. Which goal is written in SMART form?

Target word: SMART goal **Decides:** Specific, measurable, dated.

A	Absolute language	Not achievable.
B	Dropped element	No measure or deadline.
C	Camouflage	About the planner, not a measurable learning outcome.
D	Correct	Specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A student ~~who works part time at a pet store~~ has these tasks: a paper due tomorrow, reviewing notes for an exam in three weeks, answering a group chat about weekend plans, and scrolling social media. ~~Her manager just texted about next month's schedule.~~ Which task should she do first?

Target word: urgent and important **Decides:** Paper due tomorrow.

A	Confusion set	Important but not urgent: schedule it.
B	Correct	Important and urgent: do now.
C	Camouflage	Not due now and not tied to the academic deadline.
D	Adjacent category	Feels urgent but is not important.

7. Answer C Concept 4 · transfer

In the Eisenhower matrix, what should be done with a task that is important but not urgent, like building a weekly study plan?

Target word: quadrant action **Decides:** Important, not urgent.

A	Adjacent category	Delegation is for urgent but unimportant tasks.
B	Confusion set	That is for urgent and important tasks.
C	Correct	Important but not urgent tasks are planned.
D	Inverted operation	Dropping is for tasks that are neither.

8. Answer B Concept 5

A student searching the library database for sources on sleep and memory gets 48,000 results. ~~She is using the library's mobile app on her tablet.~~ How should she change her search to narrow the results?

Target word: narrow results **Decides:** AND requires all terms.

A	Dropped element	Dropping a key term broadens results.
B	Correct	AND requires every term, narrowing results.
C	Camouflage	The device does not affect the search logic.
D	Inverted operation	OR broadens results.

9. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

A student's search for "teen" AND "anxiety" returns only 6 results. Which change will broaden it the most while staying on topic?

Target word: reverse: broaden **Decides:** OR adds synonyms.

A	Adjacent category	Excludes a key synonym.
B	Inverted operation	Another AND narrows further.
C	Confusion set	NOT excludes the main topic.
D	Correct	OR adds synonyms and widens results.

10. Answer A Concept 6

A student writing about the effects of screen time on sleep finds four sources. ~~One appears on a website with a sleek modern design.~~ Which source is most credible for an academic paper?

Target word: most credible **Decides:** Peer-reviewed, current, authoritative.

A	Correct	Current, peer-reviewed, expert authors.
B	Camouflage	Design is not credibility.
C	Adjacent category	Its purpose is to sell.
D	Dropped element	Not current or peer-reviewed.

11. Answer C Concept 7

A student reads an article and writes the author's main argument in her own words. ~~She finished the paragraph at 2 a.m. and saved it to the cloud.~~ What must she do?

Target word: citation for a paraphrase **Decides:** The idea belongs to the author.

A	Confusion set	Quotation marks are for exact words.
B	Absolute language	Citations are needed wherever the source is used.
C	Correct	Paraphrased ideas must be credited.
D	Inverted operation	Rewording does not change whose idea it is.

12. Answer A Concept 8

On a timed multiple-choice exam ~~taken at a testing center with bright lights,~~ a student reads a question and sees one option says the policy "always" applies. ~~She has 40 minutes left.~~ What is the best strategy?

Target word: test strategy **Decides:** Absolute words are often wrong; predict and eliminate.

A	Correct	Prediction and elimination improve accuracy.
B	Camouflage	Lighting does not decide the strategy.
C	Dropped element	Skips reading all options.
D	Inverted operation	Absolute options are frequently incorrect.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	5	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Spaced practice	Spreading study over several shorter sessions across days produces better long-term retention than cramming the same hours into one session.	Believing one long session is equally effective if the total time is the same.	The same total hours arranged differently.
2	Retrieval practice	Actively recalling information (self-quizzing, flashcards, practice questions) strengthens memory more than rereading or highlighting.	Mistaking familiarity from rereading for learning.	A choice between rereading and testing yourself.
3	SMART goals	Effective goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.	Writing a vague wish with no measure or deadline.	Choosing or fixing a goal statement.
4	Urgent vs. important (Eisenhower matrix)	Do important-and-urgent tasks now, schedule important-but-not-urgent tasks, delegate urgent-but-unimportant ones, and drop tasks that are neither.	Letting urgent but unimportant interruptions crowd out important work.	A list of tasks to prioritize.
5	Boolean searching	AND narrows a search (all terms required), OR broadens it (any term), NOT excludes a term.	Using AND to find more results.	Too many or too few database results.
6	Evaluating source credibility	Judge sources on currency, relevance, authority, accuracy, and purpose (CRAAP); scholarly work favors peer-reviewed, current sources.	Trusting a source because it looks professional or is popular.	Choosing among sources for an academic paper.
7	Integrating and citing sources	Quotations need quotation marks and a citation; paraphrases and summaries still need a citation; only common knowledge and your own ideas are uncited.	Skippping the citation because the words were changed.	A writer using another author's idea.
8	Test-taking strategy	Read the full stem, predict the answer, eliminate clearly wrong options, and be wary of absolute words like always and never.	Picking the first option that looks familiar.	A multiple-choice strategy question.

Course scope (public description): Learning Strategies in Higher Education provides students with a toolbox of skills that will support student academic growth as they advance in their academic journey. Students will be introduced to the WGU Library; how to use it and best practices for research strategies. Students will learn how to be professional in written communication and how to properly integrate and cite source materials in academic papers. In this course, students also will learn about setting goals, time-management, study strategies, making and keeping appointments, professional decorum, and test-taking skills. Learning these skills, strategies, and methods will establish an academic foundation for students to be successful in higher education. There are no prerequisites for this course.